Fresh from the success of what it calls "Season 1"—the agitation against the leaked question paper of the National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (NEET) at Delhi's Jantar Mantar that culminated in the resignation of Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan on July 25—the CJP is attempting something considerably more ambitious. It is taking a movement born on Instagram to India's villages and towns and widening its original battle over exam fairness into a campaign about education, jobs, health and state accountability.

Importantly, it is discovering what happens when digital activism meets power on the ground. In Thanagazi in Rajasthan's Alwar district, CJP co-convenor Ashutosh Ranka and organisation co-head Deepak Baliyan reached after students began protesting over the state of their school. The 180 students here have three teachers and just three rooms; water leaks through the classrooms and there is no usable toilet or proper drinking water. Some of the children protesting were six or seven years old. Their slogan was startlingly direct: 'Give us teachers or give us TCs (transfer certificates to go to other schools).'

Something has changed. When the protests began at Jantar Mantar, Baliyan recalls, only 200-300 people turned up initially. Many were frightened of confronting a powerful government. "Now," he says, "that fear among the youth has completely disappeared. Now, we are not afraid of officialdom. Now, they are afraid of us." That psychological shift is what Ashok Dhawale, member of the CPI(M) politburo, too, regards as the CJP's first success. "The most important thing the CJP achieved was the demolition of fear," he says. Something he believes has also emboldened Opposition parties and groups that had supported the protests.

However, now comes the much harder transition and the bigger question: can the CJP transform its movement into a major political force across the country?

Pressure Group or Political Party?

As its first avatar, the CJP prefers to be more of a "pressure group" rather than a political movement, as Dipke puts it. "People have lost faith in all institutions," he tells INDIA TODAY. "People's representatives change loyalties soon after being elected. India needs a social movement in which people rise above political affiliations." That said, he doesn't rule out the CJP emerging as a political party at some point, "If the people want us to, we will have to consider it," he says. "But we have no such plans now."

The lure of electoral politics, however, may be hard for the CJP to resist, given the sheer weight of the constituency it seeks to mobilise. Those aged 18-29 account for nearly 30 per cent of India's voting-age population. Tamil Nadu demonstrated what can happen when this demographic heft translates into votes: Vijay's Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) drew around 60 per cent support among young voters, helping propel the fledgling party to a 108-seat win (out of a total of 234), breaking the



REALITY CHECK Dipke interacts with students at a government school in Hingoli, Maharashtra, Aug. 18

"What they think about the CJP"



"CJP's strength is its ability to caricature political figures, including the PM. There is nothing more toxic to a leader than to become an object of satire. It strips them of their mystique"

— JAIRAM RAMESH

Congress general secretary



"The BJP has built a 20th-century political machine around grassroots organisation. But will that prove as decisive in the social media age, when CJP has demonstrated the power of speed, digital reach and horizontal connectivity?"

— PROF. THOMAS BLOM HANSEN

Political anthropologist, Stanford University